

SUEDE DESIGNATHON 2026

What judges look for.

The clearest available model of how SUEDE judges
are likely to assess the work.

What is confirmed.

The last published rubric had five parts.

Problem identification Did the team identify and understand the problem?	Solution approach Does the product effectively solve that problem?	Design innovation Is the solution creative and innovative?	Visual communication How well does the design look and feel?	Presentation skills How clearly does the team communicate its ideas?
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Problem identification.

2024 WORDING

How well did you identify and understand the problem?

Who? Is the user specific enough to understand their needs?

When? Is there a clear moment where the problem occurs?

Why? Is the underlying cause explained, not only the symptom?

Evidence? What proves the problem matters to a real person?

STRONG

One user, one situation, a clear tension and evidence that changes the framing.

WEAK

A broad social issue, an invented persona and research facts with no consequence.

Solution approach.

2024 WORDING

How effective is your product at solving the problem?

Connection?	Does the mechanism directly address the cause you identified?
Outcome?	What becomes easier, safer or better for the user?
Core flow?	Can judges see the value happen in the prototype?
Scope?	Is the main solution complete enough to believe?

STRONG

A visible line from problem to action to outcome, shown through one complete flow.

WEAK

A list of features that sounds useful but does not resolve the identified problem.

Design innovation.

2024 WORDING

How creative and innovative is your solution?

Angle? Is the interpretation of the brief different from the obvious response?

Mechanism? Does it change behaviour in a useful or unexpected way?

Context? Is the idea placed where the problem actually happens?

Comparison? Can the team explain how it differs from existing solutions?

STRONG
A distinct insight or mechanism with a clear reason it is better for this problem.

WEAK
A familiar app, dashboard or chatbot with the brief added as content.

Visual communication.

2024 WORDING

How well does your design look and feel?

Hierarchy?

Can a judge see what matters and what happens next?

Consistency?

Do type, colour, spacing and components feel deliberate?

Usability?

Does the visual design help people understand the interaction?

Fit?

Does the style suit the user, setting and idea?

STRONG

Enough fidelity to communicate clearly, with craft focused on the critical moments.

WEAK

Decoration, effects and perfect mockups covering an unclear interaction.

Presentation skills.

2024 WORDING

How well does your team present and communicate your ideas?

Clarity?	Can judges explain the idea back after hearing it once?
Story?	Does the pitch move from problem to insight to solution to proof?
Demo?	Is the important interaction shown without confusion?
Editing?	Has the team removed details that do not support the argument?

STRONG

One sentence for the idea, one clear demo and only the evidence needed to believe it.

WEAK

A chronological process diary, too many speakers or a demo that needs narration to work.

The criteria are connected.

Problem	Approach	Innovation	Visuals	Pitch
Do we understand it?	Does the response make sense?	Is the angle distinct?	Can we see it clearly?	Can we understand and remember it?

A polished final stage cannot fully repair a weak first stage.

What likely separates the overall winner.

A specific interpretation.

The project does not simply answer the topic. It finds a precise behaviour, setting or tension that other teams miss.

Visible impact.

The judge can see what changes for the user.

A believable flow.

The main interaction works as an argument.

Evidence of judgment.

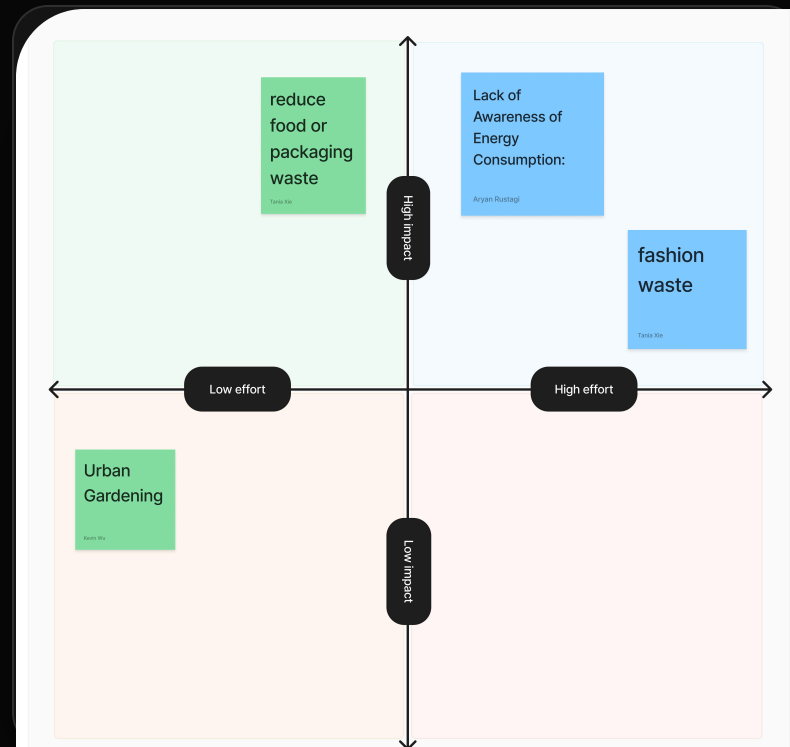
Research and testing changed the design.

A memorable story.

The team makes the value easy to repeat.

What Hot Topic shows.

The 2025 winner focused on the comments below
ideas people already watch the address digital



What strong evidence looks like.

We understand the user.

A sourced behaviour, direct observation or interview finding tied to a specific moment.

The problem matters.

A visible consequence for the user, not only a large statistic.

The idea is useful.

People can explain the value back or choose it over a clear alternative.

The flow works.

A task test reveals where people succeed, hesitate or fail, followed by a design change.

The idea is distinct.

A comparison with existing responses showing the different insight or mechanism.

The idea is feasible.

A simple explanation of how it works, what is assumed and what is outside scope.

What judges can reject quickly.

It misses the brief.

The team solves a related issue but not the actual task.

It feels generic.

The same idea could answer several unrelated briefs.

The research is decorative.

Insights appear in the deck but do not affect the solution.

It takes too long to understand.

The problem, user or value remains unclear after the opening explanation.

The prototype proves nothing.

Screens exist, but the important change for the user is not demonstrated.

The submission is incomplete.

Required links, credits, files or team information are missing.

Review the concept like a judge.

What exact problem are we solving?

Why does this mechanism solve that problem?

What can judges see working?

What evidence makes us believe it matters?

What is different from the obvious response?

Can someone explain the idea back in one sentence?

Review the final entry like a judge.

Does every requirement appear in the submission?

Does the demo show the core value clearly?

Does the visual design help understanding?

Does the opening make the problem specific?

Do we show what research or testing changed?

What will judges remember ten minutes later?

What this means for our time.

OPENING

Problem + innovation

Spend enough time to find a specific problem and a non-obvious response.

MIDDLE

Approach + proof

Use the prototype and testing to show that the core mechanism works.

FINAL

Visuals + presentation

Make the strongest argument easy to see, understand and remember.

The schedule should follow the weakest part of the judging case, not a fixed production ritual.

Sources.

Confirmed criteria and evidence are separated from our interpretation.

01	SUEDE 2024	Five published judging criteria and award categories.
02	SUEDE 2025	Public criteria listed as TBA and separate awards.
03	SUEDE posts	Top-three language and event context.
04	Judge reflection	Final storytelling across more than 30 teams.
05	Hot Topic	2025 first-place project.
06	FreTo	2024 first-place process and testing.
07	Devpost judging	Typical idea, implementation and impact criteria.
08	Devpost judge advice	Requirements, originality, UX, demo and story.